

ARES Protocol — Quick Start

How a robot connects to ARES: register, heartbeat, claim, release

REST/XML

ROS2DDS

A robot does exactly four things: **register** once, **heartbeat** while it runs, **claim** the space it needs, and **release** when done. Each call carries a **key** and gets back a tiny **decision + reason**. That is the whole protocol — this page is all most integrations need.

REST/XML and ROS2DDS are shown here. JSON, native Zenoh, route planning, scheduling, snapshots and the fine-level “tier-2” calls live in **PROTOCOL-advanced.typ**.

1 Connect

Transport	Address
REST / XML	<code>http://<host>:8080/ares/v1/...</code> — send/accept <code>application/xml</code> .
ROS2DDS	ROS2 service <code>/ares/v1/...</code> , type <code>ares_interfaces/srv/Json</code> (a JSON string in, a JSON string out), via <code>zenoh-bridge-ros2dds</code> .

Check the server is up (no key needed):

```
curl http://<host>:8080/ares/v1/health
# {"status":"ok","version":"0.1.0"}
```

2 The key

Each call may carry a **key**. Two forms:

Key	Meaning
an integer, e.g. <code>1234</code>	a simple numeric password
<code>did:pass=<secret></code>	a password in DID form

The key is set at **register** and bound to the robot. Every later call resends it; a wrong key is rejected with reason **1** (**mismatched key**).

The key is optional. If you omit it the server uses a shared default password — convenient but insecure (anyone can act as a robot that skipped the key). If a robot registers **with** a key, it must keep sending that same key.

3 The reply

Every call answers with the same two fields:

- decision** — **1** = ok / granted, **0** = denied.
- reason** — **0** = ok and **1** = mismatched key on **every** call; other values are listed per call below.

In XML the reply root is always `<reply>`. (On input the request’s outer tag name is ignored — only the inner fields matter.)

4 The four calls

Each call shows the XML body and the equivalent ROS2 service call. The robot id may be an **integer** or a **UUID string**.

4.1 Register

Bind a robot id to a key. Do this once. Optional `<alive>` is the heartbeat interval in seconds (default 2); if no heartbeat arrives for **2×** that, the server marks the robot inactive **and auto-releases all its claims** (so a crashed robot never leaves a zone stuck).

```
POST /ares/v1/robots
<reg><robot>7</robot><key>1234</key><alive>2</alive></reg>
<reply><decision>1</decision><reason>0</reason></reply>
```

```
ros2 service call /ares/v1/robots/register ares_interfaces/srv/Json \
  "{request: '{\"robot\":\"7\", \"key\":\"1234\", \"alive\":2}'}"
# response.success=true response.response='{"decision":1,"reason":0}'
```

reason	meaning
0	registered
1	mismatched key
2	already registered
3	bad id (not an integer or UUID)
4	unsupported key scheme

4.2 Heartbeat

Liveness + where the robot is. The reply is just an ack; the server timestamps it. Send one of `zone` / `node` / `edge`. Use `zone = -1` when the robot holds no zone and its location is unknown.

```
POST /ares/v1/robots/7/heartbeat
<hb><key>1234</key><zone>42</zone></hb>      <!-- or <zone>-1</zone> if unknown -->
<reply><decision>1</decision><reason>0</reason></reply>
```

```
ros2 service call /ares/v1/robots/heartbeat ares_interfaces/srv/Json \
  "{request: '{\"robot\":\"7\", \"key\":\"1234\", \"zone\":42}'}" # or "zone":-1 if unknown
# response.success=true response.response='{"decision":1,"reason":0}'
```

reason	meaning
0	ok
1	mismatched key
2	not registered

4.3 Claim

Reserve a zone (or node/edge — the type is in the path). To reserve several at once, repeat `<id>`; it is **all-or-nothing**. On denial, `<blocked>` names the id that stopped it. Two optional fields:

Field	Meaning
<code><access_mode></code>	<code>0</code> = unspecified ($\rightarrow$ exclusive), <code>1</code> = exclusive (default), <code>2</code> = shared; <code>3</code> + reserved and rejected.
<code><lease_time></code>	seconds the claim should hold: <code>0</code> (default) = unlimited, <code>X</code> = X seconds.

Shared zones. On a zone whose capacity is greater than 1, several robots may hold it at once with `access_mode=2` (shared), up to that capacity; once full, a further shared claim is denied with reason `3` (**capacity exceeded**). An **exclusive** claim (`access_mode=1`) on a shared zone still **conflicts** with the current holders (reason `2`).

Lease time, today. `<lease_time>` is accepted but timed wall-clock expiry is not enforced yet: only `0` (unlimited) is currently effective, and a non-zero value is accepted but the claim is **not** auto-expired on a timer today. The expiry that does work is auto-release when a robot stops heartbeating (after `2×` its `alive` interval).

```
POST /ares/v1/claims/zone
<claim><key>1234</key><robot>7</robot><id>42</id></claim>
<reply><decision>1</decision><reason>0</reason></reply>

<!-- several zones, atomic, exclusive, 30-second lease -->
<claim><key>1234</key><robot>7</robot><id>42</id><id>43</id>
  <access_mode>1</access_mode><lease_time>30</lease_time></claim>
<reply><decision>0</decision><reason>2</reason><blocked>43</blocked></reply>
```

```
ros2 service call /ares/v1/claims/zone ares_interfaces/srv/Json \
  "{request: '{\"key\": \"1234\", \"robot\": \"7\", \"id\": [42]}'}"
# response.success=true response.response={"decision":1,"reason":0}'

# several zones, atomic, exclusive, 30-second lease – id is an ARRAY even for one
ros2 service call /ares/v1/claims/zone ares_interfaces/srv/Json \
  "{request: '{\"key\": \"1234\", \"robot\": \"7\", \"id\": [42,43], \"access_mode\": 1, \"lease_time\": 30}'}"
# response.success=true response.response={"decision":0,"reason":2,"blocked":43}'
```

reason	meaning
0	granted
1	mismatched key
2	conflict — someone holds it
3	capacity exceeded (shared zone full)
4	unknown id
5	bad request (no id, or unsupported <code>access_mode</code>)

Claiming a zone reserves everything inside it — so a zone claim and a claim on a node/edge within that zone conflict with each other.

4.4 Release

Give back what this robot holds on a resource.

```
POST /ares/v1/leases/release/zone
<rel><key>1234</key><robot>7</robot><id>42</id></rel>
<reply><decision>1</decision><reason>0</reason></reply>
```

```
ros2 service call /ares/v1/leases/release/zone ares_interfaces/srv/Json \
  "{request: '{\"key\": \"1234\", \"robot\": \"7\", \"id\": 42}'}"
# response.success=true response.response={"decision":1,"reason":0}'
```

reason	meaning
0	released
1	mismatched key
2	no such lease (robot holds nothing there)
3	unknown id

5 A full run

```
B=http://<host>:8080/ares/v1
xml() { curl -s -X POST "$B$1" -H 'content-type: application/xml' -d "$2"; echo; }

xml /robots          '<reg><robot>7</robot><key>1234</key></reg>'
xml /claims/zone     '<claim><key>1234</key><robot>7</robot><id>42</id></claim>'
xml /robots/7/heartbeat '<hb><key>1234</key><zone>42</zone></hb>'
xml /leases/release/zone '<rel><key>1234</key><robot>7</robot><id>42</id></rel>'
```

The same run over ROS2 — register, claim, heartbeat, release:

```
J=ares_interfaces/srv/Json

ros2 service call /ares/v1/robots/register $J "{request: '{\"robot\": \"7\", \"key\": \"1234\"}'}"
ros2 service call /ares/v1/claims/zone $J "{request: '{\"key\": \"1234\", \"robot\": \"7\", \"id\": [42]}'}"
ros2 service call /ares/v1/robots/heartbeat $J "{request: '{\"robot\": \"7\", \"key\": \"1234\", \"zone\": 42}'}"
ros2 service call /ares/v1/leases/release/zone $J "{request: '{\"key\": \"1234\", \"robot\": \"7\", \"id\": 42}'}"
```

JSON note. On JSON the claim `id` is an array — `{"id": [42]}` for one, `{"id": [42, 43]}` for several. (XML just repeats `<id>`.) Numeric `robot / key` may be quoted strings. See `PROTOCOL-advanced.typ` for the JSON transport.